“So, You’ve Discovered Sleeves!”: The Reinforcement of Hypersexualized Gender Norms in Resident Evil Remakes

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ABSTRACT

The hypersexualization of major female characters in video games can be attributed to the industry’s portrayal of gender norms when catering to the male-gaze. In recent years, survival horror video games have endured remasters/remakes in attempts to modernize the content for a contemporary audience—redesigning visuals, character designs, and user interfaces. This study examines how *Resident Evil* remakes have redesigned female characters’ outfits via textual analysis through a feminist lens. Hypersexualization by visual cues, such as the amount of exposed skin, exaggerated body parts, and visible cleavage, were considered through iterative comparison of the original and remade designs. Upon determining the initial level of hypersexualization led to questioning of how the design's amendments attributed to an emphasis on the perceived gender norms and female stereotypes in the original titles. Evidence determined a reduction of hypersexualized gender norms in remakes, and an evident gap in hypersexualization between original and remade designs.

Keywords: video games, sexualization, feminist media, gender norms, survival horror

INTRODUCTION

The video game industry has long portrayed female characters through hypersexualized designs, thus contributing to players’ expectations of gender norms, stereotypes, and how a woman should behave or present herself. As major developers release remakes of late 90s to early 2000s video games, remakes must determine ways by which they will amend or defend the original portrayals of their major female characters. Capcom, a Japanese game company, has tackled this dilemma in recent years upon releasing new editions of the *Resident Evil* series—with updated graphics and altered character models.

While research often analyzes hypersexualization in original games or the

industry, fewer studies focus on progression and reinterpretations of character models belonging to the same game. This study will analyze how Capcom have redesigned their major female protagonists in their latest remakes: *Resident Evil 2* (2019), *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis* (2020), and *Resident Evil 4* (2023)—as well as their respective original titles from 1998, 1999, and 2005. Textual analysis through a feminist lens highlights the reduction of hypersexualized gender norms in *Resident Evil* remakes but emphasizes the extent to which original designs relied on these concepts among each female character.

LITERATURE REVIEW

On the topic of gender norms and hypersexualization within video games, gender stereotyping is a related concept that is often placed upon female characters. De la Torre-Sierra and Guichot-Reina provide a definition of gender stereotypes in "Women in Video Games: An Analysis of the Biased Representation of Female Characters in Current Video Games":

> "A generalized view or preconception about attributes or characteristics, or the roles that are or ought to be possessed by, or performed by, women and men. A gender stereotype is harmful when it limits women's and men's capacity to develop their personal abilities, pursue their professional careers and/or make choices about their lives" (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024, p.534).

The video game industry frequently perpetuates these stereotypes through repeated usage of exaggerated body features, such as a voluptuous chest and visible cleavage (Beasley et al., 2002; Brock, 2011; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023), skin-tight clothing, and a slim figure (Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023) which researchers often measure through content analysis (Beasley et al., 2002; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Miller et al., 2007).

The decision-making behind these character designs can be attributed to the 'male-gaze', which game developers cater to when creating a titular or supporting female character to appeal to their main audience: male video game players (Beasley et al., 2002; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Tabares, 2023). In short, the 'male-gaze' refers to the highly sexualized lens a female character is viewed from based on established social and gender norms (Kondrat, 2015).

Various gender stereotypes have been birthed from the male-gaze, with one major stereotype being the 'damsel-in-distress' dynamic that female characters are cornered into (Kondrat, 2015; Liu, 2019; Purnomo et al., 2025; Tabares, 2023)—in which a helpless female must be saved by a heroic male to avoid harm or escape captivity—and another, the 'femme fatale', who is a beautiful embodiment of womanly evil that a male must sexually resist (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024). Both the male-gaze and damsel-in-distress dynamic endorse the portrayal of female characters as sex objects, objects of desire, and objects to obtain within video games (Brock, 2011; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Kondrat, 2015; Miller et al., 2007).

Multiple scholars also emphasize the large role clothing plays in reinforcing gender

perception. Male-oriented outfits are, not only skin-tight, but entirely impractical in regard to the physical exertion female leads perform (Beasley et al., 2002; Brock, 2011; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023). Additionally, some video games offer exclusive outfits that are unlockable only after the main campaign of the story is completed (Purnomo et al., 2025). *Resident Evil 5*, a survival-horror game that includes unlockable outfits, offers alternative clothing for the main female character that is more revealing than her default outfit. These alternative outfits are titled: "Clubbin" and "Tribal" in the rewards shop, and "exoticize and sexualize her simultaneously" (Brock, 2011, p.438) by exploiting her body parts and depicting her exhibiting gender and racial stereotypes.

Additionally, Feminist Media Theory is also a key factor in how a player's perception of female video game characters is shaped through use of visuals and gameplay. De la Torre-Sierra and Guichot-Reina provide a definition of this:

> "Feminist Media Theory encompasses a complex range of approaches, all of which critically examine how gender norms are constructed, maintained, and reinforced in the media. At the core of this theory is the challenge to powerful and pervasive gender norms that are deeply entrenched in media representations. These representations contribute to reinforcing inequalities in broader social life by perpetuating stereotypical portrayals of women as subordinate, sexualized, or dependent on male counterparts" (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024, p.535).

Kondrat (2015) supports Feminist Media Theory through quantitative data that resulted from a closed-ended questionnaire and analysis. Participants of the questionnaire reported being majority male and believed female characters to be sexualized often—further proving the video game industry to be male-dominated and at fault for perpetuating female stereotypes that establish gender norms and sex-role expectations (Kondrat, 2015).

Studies also elaborated upon the extent by which most players are young men, comparing that to the lack of female players in the industry (Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023); and tying into the concept of the male-gaze. This audience of young males has a significant impact on the perpetuated use of gender stereotypes in video games through sexualization of female characters in online forums and social media posts. Brock (2011) discusses an instance where an online forum shared a screengrab from *Resident Evil 5*, in which the main female character was wearing an outfit that exposed her breasts, stomach, and upper thighs. This image circulated online forums due to male players reposting it with captions of "upskirt shots of Tribal Sheva [the female character]" and guides on how to position the male character in between her cleavage (Brock, 2011).

Tabares (2023) delves into a similar issue among online forums related to *Resident Evil 8: Village*. Prior to the game's release, Capcom, the developing company, published a description of the character: Lady Dimitrescu. This character description went viral online and fell victim to

hypersexualization and fetishization, causing the developers to enlarge the character's butt and breasts in the final design in order to appeal to players' desires (Tabares, 2023). Additionally, Capcom went so far as to include a scene in which the player sneaks up and "paddles her butt with a fly swatter to appeal to fan service" (Tabares, 2023, p.7)—emphasizing the power of online video game forums when in control of the male audience.

The major social impact of online video game forums and perceptions of video game characters that follow game releases and virality can be connected to Social Comparison Theory. Social Comparison Theory regards the self-perception processes by which "individuals compare themselves to others in order to measure their own abilities and successes" (Miller et al., 2007, p.734). This theory becomes especially harmful within the video game industry because of the hypersexualized portrayals of female characters that internalizes gender stereotypes and inflicts them upon real women; influencing the sexual and behavioral perception of societal women by players (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Kondrat, 2015; Liu, 2019; Tabares, 2023).

Miller (2007) expands upon this by asking the question: How do these portrayals impact players who may consider the female character a role model? Social Comparison Theory helps provide an answer, by explanation that young girls or women whom identity with a female character "may seek to emulate the character in terms of her sexy appearance or attire, which can be damaging to self-esteem, and also might contribute to ailments such as eating disorders" (Miller, 2007, p.740). This article, "Gender Differences in Video Game Characters' Roles, Appearances, and Attire as Portrayed in Video Game Magazines", additionally explains how children are the most impressionable audience of video games, and these designs actively contribute to the creation of gender stereotypes and gender norms by younger generations.

Overall, researchers believe there is a lack of knowledge in regard to gender norms and stereotypes within the game developing community. De la Torre-Sierra and Guichot-Reina (2024) emphasize the need for an inclusive and diverse expanse of female characters in video games, and how this expanse could facilitate an empowering and safe environment for young women should developers prioritize awareness and education on the topic.

While much of the existing research on video games delves into player responses and perception, fewer studies address how these issues stand in modern-day video game remakes. A study by Logan Brown (2024), titled "Rethinking Remakes: Value and Culture in Video Game Temporalization", introduces the concept of "temporalization" which he defines as:

> "Temporalization is, put simply, the adaptation of a work across time. Like localization, temporalization redefines the cultural and technical changes a game undergoes away from the realm of authenticity[...]and towards[...]culturalization , that is, aesthetic change that "helps gamers to engage with the game's content at a much deeper, more meaningful level … [and that]

> ensures that gamers will not be disengaged from the game by a piece of content that is considered incongruent or even offensive" (Brown, 2024, p.338).

The definition describes the cultural and societal impacts that the modern day has on older video games (Liu, 2019), ranging from the early 1980s to 2000s, and how aesthetic changes help players engage with the content in a more personable and meaningful manner (Brown, 2024). It is vital that developers maintain the original messages and themes of the title, while modernizing it for contemporary players who expect culturally significant alterations given the current time. Thus, creating a thin line between restorative nostalgia—" restoring past for an enjoyment of the present" (Purnomo et al., 2025, p.3)—and temporalization (Brown, 2024) that portrayals of gender stereotypes, catering to the male-gaze, and femininity may shine or suffer by.

Furthermore, the composition of these studies beg the question of how modern-day remakes address previous portrayals of female characters through alterations and amendments of their original designs—given the lack of current analyses pertaining to all three subjects of study: female character models, social and cultural impacts on hypersexuality and gender norms, and video game remakes. It is relevant to research themes which connect these topics to gain insights and implications for future female protagonist designs and portrayals.

CONTEXTUAL DEFINITIONS

Combat attire
Clothing that is worn by a character while performing a negative physical action against another individual.
Gender norms
Expectations of how an individual should present themselves and behave, that are determined by socially conformed structures (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024).
Hypersexualization
Sexualization that "occurs when society demonstrates[...]whether implicitly or explicitly, that a woman's value comes primarily or solely from her sexual appeal, when she is sexually objectified, or when sexuality is inappropriately imposed on her, and where her other characteristics are excluded" (Sidani, 2023, p.193).
Male-gaze
The lens by which women are viewed as objects of desire —commonly by skin-tight clothing, accentuated figures, or slim bodies—and are created to serve males as sexual objects or aids (Kondrat, 2015).
Practical
That of maximizing function and efficiency in each situation; prioritizing the suitability of an object's purpose.
Screengrab
A stilled media frame from footage belonging to a video game, film, television show, or another form of digital media.

Temporalization
The adaptation of a work across time which reflects cultural and technical changes in favor of authenticity, to encourage engagement and connection between players and games (Brown, 2024).
Video game remaster or remake
A modern release of a video game that has enhanced or updated graphics, design, user interface, and character models; but the same overall story.
Visual design
The aesthetics and appearance of a message that is communicated visually.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This paper is an examination of how modern remasters of classic *Resident Evil* video games, developed by Capcom, revise the hypersexualized models of their major female characters by use of updated character and outfit designs. While these remasters intend to correct and amend the original hypersexualized designs, it is possible that these revisions highlight and reinforce the hypersexualized norms embedded in said designs in attempts to modernize them. To break this concept down into feasible research questions, I have divided it into two main topics of study to delve further into—RQ1 being descriptive and RQ2 focusing on interpretation—as well as two hypotheses:

RQ1
How have modern remasters of Resident Evil video games revised the hypersexualized outfits of their major female characters?
RQ2
In what ways do these revisions reinforce the hypersexualized norms embedded in the original designs in attempts to amend them?

H1
The visual communication of the female characters has far less hypersexualization in modern redesigns in comparison with the original designs, due to efforts to make the female outfits less revealing.
H2
In attempts to make corrections, the remasters expose the degree to which the originals were designed to appease the male-gaze—further amplifying the pre-existing hypersexualized gender norms that were placed upon the female characters.

This study's research will be completed via qualitative textual analysis though a feminist lens, to prioritize interpretive exploration of hypersexualization over time and intangible themes of gender norms and stereotypes (Gangadharbatia et al., 2023). Framework and theories—such as Feminist Media Theory and the male-gaze, Social Comparison Theory, and contemporary temporalization—will be considered when analyzing the data to determine connections between portrayals of femininity in *Resident Evil* releases and remakes.

Data collection will be performed by analyzing three female protagonists' combat

outfits in their respective games. These characters will be Claire Redfield from *Resident Evil 2* (1998) and *Resident Evil 2* (2019), Jill Valentine from *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis* (1999) and *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis* (2020), and Ada Wong from *Resident Evil 4* (2005) and *Resident Evil 4* (2023). One unit of analysis will pertain to a screengrab of a female protagonist in their combat outfit—first, from the original release and secondly, from the remake.

To address the RQ1, analytical criteria (as listed below) will be used to code each unit of analysis. Furthermore, RQ2 will be addressed via iterative comparison between original and remake to identity similarities or differences in applied framework and theories.

C1
Emphasis on skin-tight clothing, particularly garments that outline a character's breasts, buttocks, or overall bodily curvature.
C2
Slim bodies or exaggerated body proportions, such as unrealistically small waists, pronounced busts, or elongated legs.
C3
Accentuated or sexualized body parts, including visible cleavage or exposed areas of skin (e.g. stomach, thighs, shoulders, or chest).
C4
Visual design choices that prioritize sexualization over realism or practicality such as impractical fabric choices, cut-off sleeves, short skirts in combat attire, or lack of better protection in combat attire given the survival horror setting.

The inclusion criteria for units of analysis are as follows: Front-facing and full-bodied (i.e. from head to toe) images of Claire Redfield, Jill Valentine, and Ada Wong. The image must be of clear quality and portray the character in their basic game outfit (i.e. the outfit the game settings portray them in without player interference), in either the original release or modern remake. The outfit pictured must be a replica of the exact outfit each character wears upon introduction in gameplay.

The exclusion criteria for units of analysis are as follows: Fan-made art, blurry images, alternative outfits that players must intentionally dress the characters in, images that do not show the entire body (i.e. from head to toe), images that have edited bodies or outfits, nor images in which the character is only facing backwards.

RESIDENT EVIL REMAKES: REVISIONS OF HYPERSEXUALIZATION

This section provides a qualitative textual analysis on the evidence of hypersexualized gender norms in female *Resident Evil* character designs. Themes of hypersexualization— skin-tight clothing, exaggerated body proportions, sexualized body parts, and prioritization of sexualization over practicality— were considered meaningful evidence of gender norms resulting from the male-gaze and were interpreted via feminist framework. Each character was analyzed in her original outfit, followed by her outfit in her

respective remake, to evaluate how both revisions perpetuate hypersexuality in video games and whether the remakes offer any meaningful alterations to the portrayal of female characters.

RESIDENT EVIL 2 (1998 & 2019)

Claire Redfield is one of two main protagonists of *Resident Evil 2*, originally released in 1998 and later remade in 2019. She is a nineteen-year-old, white college student whose motives stem from her desire to find her missing older brother in an apocalyptic city. Here, she is stalked by a large mutant while defeating infected humans along the way. Her campaign is of equal importance to the male protagonist of the game, Leon Kennedy's, and can be completed before or after his campaign. *Resident Evil 2* is her first and only appearance in the main series and takes place during September of 1998.

Claire Redfield's Original Model

Of the three characters, Claire is a unique case because her original 1998 design includes official concept art that explicitly states what materials her outfit is made of (See Figure 1). The concept art labels her boots as leather ("皮のブーツ")、 black shorts and undershirt as nylon spandex ("ナイロン[...]スパッツ"), red shorts as denim jeans ("ジーンズ(デニム)"), and vest as a nylon flight jacket with the sleeves cut off ("フライトジャケット(ナイロン)"). These details offer additional insight into Claire's original visual design that other character outfits lack.

Figure 1. Claire Redfield concept art from *Resident Evil 2* (1998).

The general appearance of Claire's original outfit (See Figure 2) includes exposed skin on her forearms, upper arms, thighs, and knees (C3). The black spandex shorts and undershirt cling to her figure (C1) and add dark accents to her outfit, which is primarily red. There is also a tactical belt strapped to her waist that has no weapon holsters—and the short length and vivid color of the denim shorts bring attention to her lower torso and upper legs, reinforcing the sexualized presentation of youthful female protagonists in survival horror games.

Figure 1. Claire Redfield concept art from *Resident Evil 2* (1998 and 2019).

Indicators of hypersexualization pertaining to the male-gaze are present throughout this outfit—skin-tight clothing, exposed skin, and lack of practicality in clothing and fabric choices. Given her circumstance in a city overrun with viral disease and concept art containing the note explaining her cut-off sleeves, exposed skin is entirely unsuitable in respect to her own safety (C4). The absence of sleeves exceptionally lacks purpose considering the cool temperature at the beginning of autumn. This is a clear indication of Capcom prioritizing the sexualization of Claire.

That being said, Claire also exhibits a slim figure in this design (C2), which aligns with gender norms related to thinness. However, her silhouette has realistic proportions and a lack of visible cleavage. This could be attributed to her age and Capcom choosing to avoid issues that could stem from overly sexualizing a teenage character, should players seek physical representation in Claire and wish to alter oneself to resemble her appearance (Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023).

Claire Redfield's Redesigned Model

The 2019 version of Claire's outfit (See Figure 3) shows significant change from the 1998 edition in regard to coverage (H1). There is no visible skin on her arms nor legs, and her clothing has changed entirely. Her pants resemble long denim jeans, vest has been replaced with a red leather jacket, and brown boots replaced with black ankle-height boots. Her bodily proportions appear similar, if not the same, to her original design—and her tactical belt now has weapon holsters.

The reduction of skin exposure amends the prior issue of environmental practicality, and the lack of nylon clothing in replacement of more durable-appearing fabrics add to the safety elements of her outfit. While remaining form-fitting, her clothing is less tight and has noticeable wrinkles in the fabric—suggesting loose areas of clothing that leave room for flexibility and movement: two factors that are vital when considering the practicality of combat attire. The addition of weapon holsters to her tactical belt emphasizes utility, functionality, and practical reasoning behind the accessory—rather than sitting at her waist as a glorified belt.

This modernized design displays intentional corrections towards the issues displayed in the 1998 version of Claire. Her outfit prefers realistic clothing choices that are more fitting for a teenage girl in the autumn season of 1998. She is framed with more

agency in this outfit, which exhibits rationality and sensibility given her environment, circumstances, and setting; rather than unreasonable clothing choices that prioritize fashion over function. This iteration of Claire appears more fitting for a survival horror protagonist who participates in physical combat and evades infection with protective fabrics and clothing coverage.

Claire Redfield: Iterative Comparison

Between the 1998 and 2019 versions of Claire Redfield's visual design, revisions related to sexualized body parts and impractical clothing were the major alterations made by Capcom (RQ1). These changes could be attributed to the desire for more realistic portrayals of women in video games and the call for game development teams to receive inclusion training, in hopes of offering more realistic gender representation in female protagonists, as stated by De la Torre-Sierra and Guichot-Reina (2024).

The practicality of Claire's clothing in the 2019 remake invites deeper relatability between player and character, directly connecting with Brown's (2024) definition of temporalization as an adaptation that "helps gamers to engage with the game's content at a much deeper, more meaningful level" (Brown, 2024, p.338). Considering the gap between the original release and remake spans over twenty-one years, players' expectations of alterations, that of which reflect cultural and societal change, are addressed by Capcom. This is done through the amendment of excessive exposed skin and thin fabrics—the lack of which helps eradicate the hypersexualized cues of her original design.

Despite the 2019 version of *Resident Evil 2*'s reflection of temporalization, the evidence of hypersexualization within Claire's original outfit is emphasized when compared with her redesigned model. Capcom's decision to substitute every clothing piece from the original outfit with durable garments that provide more coverage highlights the extent to which the 1998 model prioritized impracticality in favor of sexualization (H2). Additionally, her slim figure remains consistent throughout both designs, further carrying related gender norms into the contemporary era of the survival horror genre (RQ2).

These changes made to Claire's model display an acknowledgement of the stereotypes originally promoted to audiences, and Capcom's attempts of correcting the hypersexualization are successful when comparing the outfits. Yes, the reinforcement of physique-related gender norms remains, but are ultimately outweighed by the improvements made to her clothing. The 2019 model of Claire Redfield is evidence of temporalization's impact on video game remakes, and how Capcom's design priorities have shifted towards creating more realistic and practical female protagonists.

***RESIDENT EVIL 3* (1999 & 2020)**

The second character under study is Jill Valentine, who is the singular protagonist of *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis*, which was originally released in 1999 and later remade in 2020. She is a twenty-three-year-old,

white-presenting, former military officer; having retired following the events of *Resident Evil*, the series' first installment which was released in 1996, where she was one of two main protagonists. Her campaign consists of gameplay where the player must evade or escape a mutant beast throughout the same city and time in which Claire's campaign occurs. There is also a deuteragonist of *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis*, who is male and named Carlos Oliveira. However, his playable portion of the campaign is significantly shorter than Jill's.

Jill Valentine's Original Model

The 1999 edition of Jill's outfit (See Figure 4, left) consists of a skin-tight, bright blue tube top and black miniskirt—that of which exposes her chest, shoulders, arms, thighs, and knees. Her cleavage protrudes from the top's neckline, with her breasts further emphasized with shading (C1). She wears knee-high brown boots and carries no accessories aside from a loose white sweater that is tied around her waist.

Figure 4. Jill Valentine in *Resident Evil: Nemesis* (1999 and 2020).

This outfit pertains to various indicators of hypersexualization based on the analytical criteria. Jill's taut clothing exaggerates her hips and bust, while the white sweater cinched at her torso draws attention to the thinness of her waist (C2). Her figure is sexualized by excessive exposed skin (C3) and portrays Jill as a sex figure rather than a practical survival horror protagonist.

Considering *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis* occurs at the same time as *Resident Evil 2;* Jill is also experiencing late summer to autumn weather. Yes, her outfit suggests she has access to warmer clothing, noted by the sweater, but dismisses the protection and warmth it may provide in favor of revealing her breasts (C4). Unlike Claire, whose outfit was more subtle in affirming analytic criteria, Jill's character model explicitly exhibits all four—propelling Jill's 1999

design as a major hypersexualized model within the units of analysis.

This design aligns with gender stereotypes that are like Claire's original model—particularly the emphasis on female protagonists inhabiting a thin figure (Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023). Jill's body appears to be slightly thinner than Claire's, in both versions of *Resident Evil 2*; which is evidence Capcom's prioritization of the male-gaze became more prevalent following the 1998 edition of *Resident Evil 2*. The developers' submission to this lens portrays Jill as a sex symbol given her outfit regarding narrative circumstances and leave much room for improvement in the game's remake.

Jill Valentine's Redesigned Model

The 2020 redesign of Jill Valentine's outfit (See Figure 4, right) provides more coverage of her legs and chest by addition of skinny jeans and a white tank top, which she wears beneath a blue tank top (H1). Her top blocks visibility of her cleavage and appears to be made of a more flexible material than her 1999 outfit—like how Claire's 2019 outfit modeled looser fabrics in favor of mobility.

This version of Jill also displays a less exaggerated slim torso and has multiple tactical straps along her legs, arms, and waist with weapon sheaths—displaying evident alterations of the original hypersexualization. Her knee-high boots have been replaced with black combat boots, and her sweater is discarded entirely.

Amendments to Jill's clothing and substitutions of accessories provide corrections to the previous issues of displaying her as a sexual figure. A majority of her outfit is considerably more practical given her gameplay, aside from her lack of protective gear covering her arms and chest. The remastered version of Jill resembles a contemporary female protagonist who partakes in physical combat and survival horror.

Jill Valentine: Iterative Comparison

Between Jill's original and redesigned model, the major differences in her outfits were the inclusion of tactical accessories—which reflect her past as a military officer—additional skin coverage, and a muted color palette (RQ1). These changes were likely made to create a more realistic female protagonist without mass hypersexualized gender norms, whom players can easily rationalize as a woman who survives a campaign of various mutants and infected peoples.

Social Comparison Theory could also contribute to these amendments about young female players who view Jill as a role model, and sought better representation of her character (Miller, 2007). As a woman with a military background, it is unreasonable to rationalize Jill donning her original outfit in a survival horror setting.

Temporalization attributes are present within these alterations by use of a similar blue, black, and white palette which are prominent in Jill's original outfit—feeding into the nostalgia aspect of video game remakes that appeal to audiences seeking aspects of the 1999 edition in the remake (Brown, 2024). The amendment of Jill's

hypersexualized figure also amends the possibility of players becoming disengaged from the remake by offense (Brown, 2024).

When placing the 1999 and 2020 outfits beside one another, the evidence of the analytical criteria is extremely prevalent by traces of the indicators of hypersexualization (RQ2 & H2). Elements such as Jill's hairstyle, muscle density, and light skin tone remain consistent between designs and do not effectively contribute to sexualized gender norms. Capcom's changes to Jill's portrayal in the 2020 edition of *Resident Evil 3: Nemesis*, provide relevant corrections to the ideologies presented in the original—strengthening Capcom's movement towards more realistic representations of female characters.

RESIDENT EVIL 4 (2005 & 2023)

As the most recent female character to undergo a remake, Ada Wong is the primary focus of study for *Resident Evil 4*, originally released in 2005 and later remade in 2023. While she is a supporting character in multiple titles within the series, *Resident Evil 4* features her as a protagonist of an additional campaign that is available upon completing the main story. She is a thirty-year-old Chinese mercenary whose motives are morally grey in comparison to lead protagonist, Leon Kennedy. Her campaign focuses on collecting biothreat samples, while defeating various mutants with zombie-like characteristics, on a remote Spanish island. This is her second of three appearances in the main series—her first being *Resident Evil 2* and last: *Resident Evil 6*.

To properly analyze Ada's character model, it is relevant to address her role as the femme fatale of the *Resident Evil* series, which De la Torre-Sierra and Guichot-Reina define as a woman who is "likely to present an unrealistic body and sexually revealing clothing[...]an embodiment of evil (*femme fatale*) that must be controlled by the male normative framework" (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024, p.553). Given this definition as a distinct object of sexuality and gender stereotype in video games, there is explicit intent behind Capcom's design choices with the clothing she is wearing.

Ada Wong's Original Model

The 2005 rendition of Ada Wong (See Figure 5) models a silky red dress, which falls to her ankles, and displays various stylistic features—such as a sweetheart neckline, halter straps, a leg slit beginning at her upper thigh, and gold butterfly embroidery. This color is prerogative to her character as she is described as "the bitch in the red dress" by an antagonist during her additional campaign in *Resident Evil 4*—which is a reference to her prominent red clothing in each of her mainline appearances. She also dons a singular tactical belt, which is strapped to her upper thigh and visible via the slit in her dress. The remaining elements of her outfit are strappy black heels and a black choker.

Figures 5 (Left) and 6 (Right). Ada Wong in *Resident Evil 4* (2005 and 2023).

Given the shape of the dress, there is emphasis on her hips and bust as well as a significant amount of exposed skin—the entirety of her right leg, both arms, and chest—indicating hypersexualization via clothing style and figure (C3). She is exceptionally skinny (C2), and her breasts and curves are highlighted via shading (C1). Her occupation as a mercenary leads a player to believe she would wear more practical clothing, assuming she would have been briefed on the physical job requirements prior to the main story, yet her design does not reflect this (C4). In parallel with Jill's original design, this version of Ada also affirms each analytical criterion.

As referenced above, Ada is a near-perfect model of the femme fatale gender stereotype (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024), considering her outfits prioritization on sex appeal and seduction. She is a sexual-presenting trap that must be dealt with by the male protagonist and reaffirms hypersexualized gender norms by means of her male-oriented outfit (Beasley et al., 2002; Brock, 2011; De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024; Kondrat, 2015; Tabares, 2023). While there is defined reasoning behind her design, this does not excuse the hypersexualized portrayal of her character in the original *Resident Evil 4*.

Ada Wong's Redesigned Model

Ada's 2023 redesign (See Figure 6) maintains her red theme and sex appeal, while completely altering her clothing. Her red dress is made of knit material and features long sleeves, a turtleneck and lack of cutouts, and ends at her upper thigh. However, she wears black leggings beneath the dress for more coverage, and her heels have been replaced with black, thigh-high leather boots. Her tactical belts now reside on her waist and chest, and she accessorizes her outfit with black gloves.

While Ada's skin is considerably less exposed (H1), the emphasis on her curves and figure remains prominent in the design due to the natural synching of her dress at the torso (C1). However, her clothing appears significantly less tight than her original outfit—which could be a result of the dress' knit material. Additionally, the inclusion of a tactical belt spanning across her chest could be argued as additional functionality for the survival horror setting; but ultimately contributes to the sexualized view of her appearance since it leads the player's eye to her bust.

This redesign frames Ada as a better prepared mercenary because she is now covered with thicker and more protective material in comparison with bare skin. There are added elements of practicality and

realism within her remake outfit, but these do not lead her character away from being a sex symbol. Her boots keep the stiletto heel of her original shoes, and the hyper-length of their height brings attention to her upper thighs, as well as the gap between her footwear and dress' hem (C4). This, along with her tactical belt, emphasizes aspects of her figure (e.g. chest, thighs, torso) that are framed in a sexual lens despite being heavily clothed. In the 2023 edition of *Resident Evil 4*, Capcom demonstrates their ability to balance pragmatism and seduction.

Ada Wong: Iterative Comparison

The major changes that were made to Ada's design in 2023 pertain to the tangible elements of her outfit, however the evidence of intangible sex appeal continues to exist. Temporalization via culturally significant alterations in remakes (Brown, 2024) may have influenced these tangible adjustments, while continuing to cater to the male-gaze with Ada's role as femme fatale. The explicit hypersexual cues of her outfit may have also been altered to reflect her own role in her sexuality and how she chooses to exude sex appeal though subtle redirection (De la Torre-Sierra et al., 2024) (RQ1).

Comparing the 2005 and 2023 iterations of Ada Wong's character model proves that a design does not have to be explicitly revealing in order to be sexual. Her figure and skin in the original design provide additional emphasis on hypersexualization and a reinforcement of norms, but do not hold a comparable level of sexualized difference as Jill and Claire's designs do. If anything, these alterations simply strengthen Ada's role as a femme fatale and intelligence in her field of seduction (H2). The *Resident Evil 4* remake did not successfully correct Ada's hypersexualization, rather reinforced the same gender norms in a more subtle way—showing Capcom's priority of maintaining Ada's gender stereotype and the developers' beliefs that her role is essential to her character (RQ2).

DISCUSSION

In this study, revisions of hypersexualization regarding major female video game characters were addressed by modern remasters/remakes of the *Resident Evil* series—as well as how these revisions reinforce the original designs embedded hypersexualized norms in attempts to amend them. Analytic criteria provided evidence of sexualization (i.e. tight clothing, unrealistic body proportions, sexualized figures, and impractical visual design) across three major characters and displayed Capcom's amendment of these criteria via body coverage. Of the three female protagonists, Ada Wong exhibited consistent prioritization on sexuality given her gender stereotype as a femme fatale—while Claire Redfield and Jill Valentine's redesigns displayed an emphasis on realism and practicality.

Limitations

As conducted by textual analysis, this study was limited by various factors. Since research primarily focused on three units of analysis (i.e. female protagonists) who belong to the *Resident Evil* series, research results cannot be generalized among all female video game protagonists. Additionally, the subjectivity of textual

analysis limits the methodology as interpretations of the data vary by researcher and preconceived perceptions. This study also excluded unlockable and additional outfits for each character to prioritize the audience's general consensus of what the character looks like. These additional outfits may have been redesigned in remakes which could influence perception related to the research questions and hypotheses. Developer intent and corporate decisions/constraints were also excluded since related information is not public and cannot be feasibly measured.

Insights & Implications

Of the data gathered regarding the three female protagonists, several insights can be made in favor of each research question and hypotheses.

I1. Realism reduces hypersexualization.

A major theme among the results of RQ1 was the reduction of hypersexualization by incorporating realism in redesigned outfits. It is apparent Capcom considered each characters' occupation (i.e. Claire as a college student, Jill as a former military officer, and Ada as a veteran mercenary) when altering designs in remakes, and chose suitable fabrics, clothing pieces, and accessories to create cohesive outfits which reflect their background (H1). This allowed the characters to appear more rational and personable women, whose visual design corresponds with the setting of survival horror and combat outfits that align with their life experiences. It is also important to note the *Resident Evil* remakes display women in outfits which transcend the time of each game—with simple color palettes and basic clothing items—reducing any future possibility of becoming outdated.

Additive realism also strengthens the positive connection between players and female video game characters via Social Comparison Theory. By amending sexualization in favor of practicality, Capcom provides updated female protagonists, who players can identify with on a meaningful level as they lack the clear gender norms of past designs, effectively de-influencing the aforementioned "sexual and behavioral perception of women by players." With this information, stakeholders should continue seeking diverse and realistic perspectives to foster better perception of female characters in the industry and broaden connections between players and protagonists.

I2. Redesigns reveal the severity of past elements of hypersexualization.

The one-to-one comparison of each character design exposed the explicit sexual nature via the number of analytical indicators in original designs and lack thereof in remakes (RQ2 & H2). Elements of the male-gaze can be attributed to the original designs, given the predominantly male audience, and have been amended because of the impact of temporalization and growing popularity of female players. To continue appealing to the broader female audience who wish for intensive revisions of hypersexualization and visual proof of developers doing so, stakeholders can capitalize from one-to-one comparisons of redesigned characters. This would display their prioritization on exhibiting social and

cultural change regarding gender norms and stereotypes.

I3. Gender norms persist in video game remakes via subtle indicators.

While outfits were entirely redesigned in *Resident Evil* remakes, each characters' figure remained consistent, if not the same, as their original design (RQ2 & H2). This is evident in their silhouettes, thinness, hair styles, and facial structures—as all three of them present themselves as objectively beautiful women, though they show less skin in recent releases. It could be argued that Capcom would be taking a large risk in editing the bodies of pre-existing characters, whom players have a deep sense of nostalgia towards, but it is necessary to have diverse body and beauty types in video games for better representation of society. An alternative that stakeholders could take to redesigning existing female characters, is to create entirely new female protagonists in upcoming video games who do not exhibit comparable amounts of gender norms and stereotypes.

I4. A character does not have to be explicitly sexualized to be sexual.

As proven by Ada Wong, the measure of coverage added to an outfit does not equal de-sexualization (RQ2, H1, & H2) since sex appeal can be exhibited in subtle and indirect ways. It is possible to portray a female character taking control of her own sexuality if it aligns with her role in the story (e.g. femme fatale), and strengthen her established personality traits via physical representations of these qualities (e.g. Ada's subtle sex appeal in her accessories and clothing hint at her seductive intelligence). Ada intentionally sexualizes herself by way of subtlety, unlike Jill nor Claire—who has sexualization forced upon them. In the future, stakeholders can consider the value of physical representations reflecting a character's mentality and personality; along with the implication that sexuality can be portrayed in less revealing ways.

Conclusion

Through analysis of three major female character designs in mainline *Resident Evil* titles, this study deepens understanding regarding the long-standing hypersexualization of female video game characters and amendment in redesigns. Moving forward, redesigns should be communicated via side-by-side comparisons to show improvement, acknowledgement of past issues, and demonstrate a developers' intent on aligning with modern cultural and social values—deepening player and character connection, lessening video game impact on gender norms and stereotypes, and seeking a more diverse array of female protagonists.

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APPENDIX (INSTRUMENT)

A1. Coding Sheet via Analytical Criteria Restated

i. **C1.** Emphasis on skin-tight clothing, particularly garments that outline a character's breasts, buttocks, or overall bodily curvature.

ii. **C2.** Slim bodies or exaggerated body proportions, such as unrealistically small waists, pronounced busts, or elongated legs.

iii. **C3.** Accentuated or sexualized body parts, including visible cleavage or exposed areas of skin (e.g. stomach, thighs, shoulders, or chest).

iv. **C4.** Visual design choices that prioritize sexualization over realism or practicality such as impractical fabric choices, cut-off sleeves, short skirts in combat attire, or lack of better protection in combat attire given the survival horror setting.

A2. Images and References

i. **Figure 1:** Claire Redfield concept art from *Resident Evil 2* (1998) (u/Blurryrock. (2023). Bio2-202009-10-26-2002-00-26-41 [Online gallery post]. Resident Evil Fandom. https://residentevil.fandom.com/wiki/Claire_Redfield/gallery?file=Bio2-202009-10-26-2002-00-26-41.png).

ii. **Figure 2:** Claire Redfield in *Resident Evil 2* (1998) (Eilers, T. (2023). *Claire Redfield – Resident Evil* [Character profile]. Writeups.org. https://www.writeups.org/claire-redfield-resident-evil/).

iii. **Figure 3:** Claire Redfield in *Resident Evil 2* (2019) (Minervino, R. (2019). Resident Evil 2 - Claire Artworks [Digital art]. ArtStation. https://rikkthegaijin.artstation.com/projects/YaPRZY).

iv. **Figure 4:** Jill Valentine in *Resident Evil: Nemesis* (1999 and 2020) (u/ResidentBeyond. (2025). Do you prefer the original Resident Evil 3 Jill or the Remake? [Online forum post]. Reddit. https://www.reddit.com/r/residentevil/comments/1lr61jz/do_you_prefer_the_original_resident_evil_3_jill/).

v. **Figure 5:** Ada Wong in *Resident Evil 4* (2005) (u/Red Chevalier. (2019). Ada1.png [Online gallery post]. Resident Evil Fandom. https://residentevil.fandom.com/wiki/Ada_Wong?file=Ada1.png).

vi. **Figure 6:** Ada Wong in *Resident Evil 4* (2023) (u/Chordyceps. (2023). Ada Wong ResE 4 Remake Outfit [Online gallery post]. Forums. https://forums.bhvr.com/dead-by-daylight/discussion/379241/ada-wong-rese4-remake-outfit).

A3. Sampling Information

i. **Inclusion Criteria:** Front-facing and full-bodied (i.e. from head to toe) images of Claire Redfield, Jill Valentine, and Ada Wong. The image must be of clear quality and portray the character in their basic game outfit (i.e. the outfit the game settings portray them in without player interference), in either the original release or modern remake. The outfit pictured must be a replica of the exact outfit each character wears upon introduction in gameplay.

ii. **Exclusion Criteria:** Fan-made art, blurry images, alternative outfits that players must

intentionally dress the characters in, images that do not show the entire body (i.e. from head to toe), images that have edited bodies or outfits, nor images in which the character is facing backwards.